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Research Article

AI-Powered Network Optimization: Application of Artificial Intelligence in Optimizing Network Performance, Including Self-Healing and Self-Optimizing Capabilities

Name: Praveen Hegde
Affiliation: Principal Engineer, Verizon
Email: praveen.m.hegde@gmail.com

Name: Robin Joseph Varughese
Affiliation: Technical Architect, Marriott International
Email: jvrobin@gmail.com

Abstract

The development of data traffic and the increasing complexity of telecommunication networks necessitate a transition from manual to intelligent network management. AI has recently emerged as a disruptive solution for network performance optimization, with the capability to handle large datasets, detect patterns, and make real-time decisions [1]. This paper considers a range of AI approaches to network optimization, especially those with self-healing and self-optimizing features. Self-healing networks utilize machine learning algorithms to automatically detect errors, perform root cause analysis, and facilitate fault recovery without human intervention. This approach enhances service availability and reduces operational expenses. Self-optimizing networks (SONs), however, dynamically adapt parameters such as bandwidth, power, and handover thresholds to provide optimal system performance in response to real-time traffic and user behavior. Incorporating AI practices (such as deep learning, reinforcement learning, and anomaly detection) into the network helps ensure that congestion, latency, and equipment failure are addressed before the problem becomes acute for a subscriber. Illustrative examples from 5G and future networks demonstrate the performance improvements in quality of service (QoS), resource utilization, and network reliability. However, model interpretability, data privacy, and deployment scalability still present significant challenges. This paper concludes with strategic insights for AI-enabled network optimization deployments, discussing the robustness of data pipelines, ethical AI governance, and the benefits of cross-layer data-driven strategies.

1. Introduction

In the era of rapid digital transformation, communication networks have become increasingly complex due to the growing number of connected devices, the demand for higher data rates, and the deployment of heterogeneous networks, such as 5G and beyond. Rule-based network management, as practiced in the past through manual configurations and static settings, is unsuitable for today's increasingly demanding conditions (Zhang et al., 2021). To address the

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challenges above, Artificial Intelligence (AI) is being increasingly embedded in ongoing network operations to provide automated, agile, and intelligent optimization.

AI-driven network optimization utilizes algorithms such as machine learning, deep learning, and reinforcement learning to continuously monitor, analyze, and control network performance. The primary advantage is that AI can process network data on a large scale, predict problems or congestion, and make real-time adjustments without human intervention (Foukas et al., 2021). This transition to intelligent automation is crucial for achieving the objectives of self-organizing networks (SONs), which are characterized by three fundamental operations: self-configuration, self-optimization, and self-healing (Aliu et al., 2013).

Self-healing mechanisms enable a network not only to detect and troubleshoot anomalies or faults but also to remediate them and return to steady-state operation. For example, if a base station fails or experiences performance degradation, AI algorithms can reroute traffic or activate a virtual network function (VNF) to ensure service continuity (Chen et al., 2022). Self-optimizing networks utilize AI to dynamically re-optimize radio settings, including transmit power, antenna tilt, and handover thresholds, thereby improving key performance indicators (KPIs) such as throughput, latency, and coverage (Liu et al., 2021).

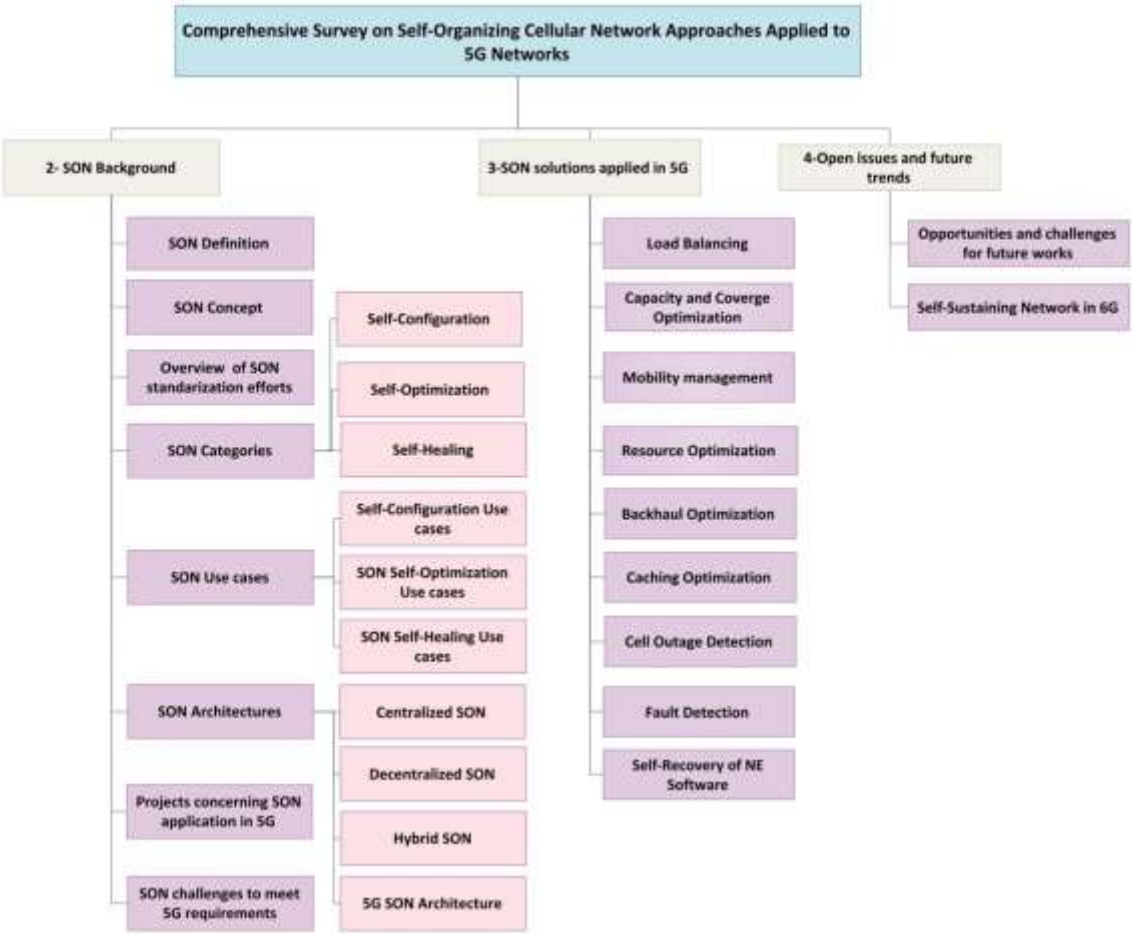

Figure 1: Self-organizing cellular network approach

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The recent breakthrough in deep reinforcement learning (DRL) enables real-time, closed-loop optimizations, with AI agents (e.g., drones) communicating with the network environment and learning optimal control policies over time. These solutions are critical in 5G and even 6G networks, where ultra-low latency and high reliability are required (Tang et al., 2022). Proactive network maintenance is another AI application that anticipates future faults, optimizes resource allocation in advance, and enhances quality of service (QoS) and the overall user experience.
Intelligence has emerged as the future of network optimization; yet, several hurdles remain to be overcome. Privacy of the data, the interpretability of the model, the time it takes to train, and the ability to scale up are some of the challenges that need to be addressed to ensure safe and efficient deployments (Barakabitze et al., 2020). Moreover, standardization and a strong data foundation are required to implement an integration approach across RAN, core network, and transport solutions.

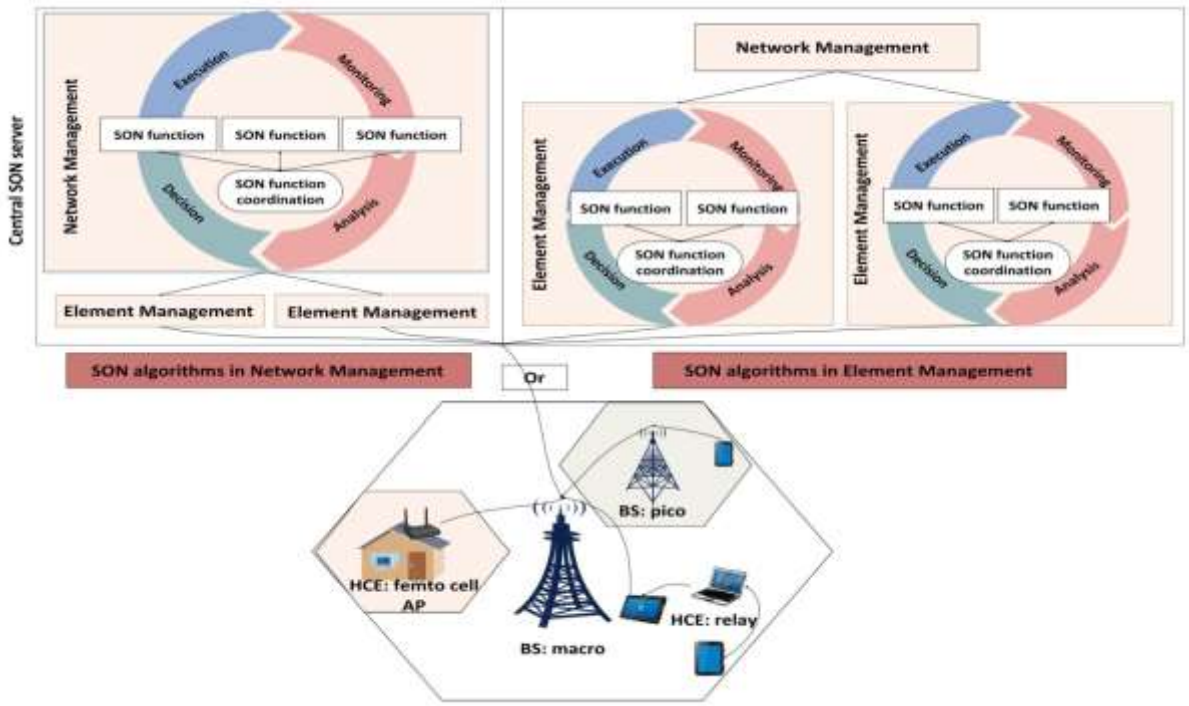

Figure 2: Network Management
The objective of this paper is to investigate current trends in AI applications for network optimization, with a focus on self-healing and self-optimizing features. It also critically reviews the fundamental AI methodologies, industry practices, and the promises and barriers brought by AI-powered intelligent networking. The objective is to equip network operators, regulators, and researchers with actionable advice for those who want to deploy next-generation autonomous network systems.

2. Literature Review

The growing complexity of modern telecommunications networks, driven by a massive surge in connected devices, real-time applications, and the rollout of 5G, has generated significant interest

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in using Artificial Intelligence (AI) to optimize network performance. This paper reviews recent research on AI for network management, with a focus on self-healing and self-optimization, as well as promising methodologies.

2.1 The Basics of AI in Network Management

Using AI for network optimization is effective because it can handle massive amounts of constantly evolving data and provide real-time intelligence. Early work by Aliu et al. (2013) proposed the concept of Self-Organizing Networks (SONs), which aim to automate configuration, optimization, and healing procedures in LTE and beyond. These fundamental concepts were further developed with the emergence of new machine learning and deep learning models capable of forecasting faults, modeling network traffic, and dynamically optimizing network parameters (Zhang et al., 2021).

Machine learning techniques, including supervised, unsupervised, and reinforcement learning, are commonly used in traffic classification, anomaly detection, and energy-efficient routing. Supervised models (such as decision trees and support vector machines) are successful in fault classification and root cause analysis, while clustering methods (like K-means and PCA) are applied to outlier and anomaly detection (Barakabitze et al., 2020). However, recent trends favor DRL-based real-time decision-making under uncertainty (Tang et al., 2022).

2.2.2 The Miscellaneous Self-Optimizing Network (SON) is a standard that enables communication between different network elements of the same family.

Self-optimization involves automatically adjusting network performance parameters, such as transmit power, antenna tilt, handover thresholds, and channel allocation, based on real-time traffic and quality KPIs. According to Liu et al. (2021), AI models can leverage usage patterns and bottlenecks to optimize both user experience and spectrum utilization proactively.

AI-enhanced SON solutions have been beneficial in 5G RAN, where heterogeneous services (e.g., eMBB, URLLC, mMTC) require service-specific performance. In such networks, deep neural networks (DNNs) and convolutional neural networks (CNNs) are utilized for predicting network load and latency, enabling dynamic resource orchestration (Chen et al., 2022). Furthermore, a distributed AI framework known as federated learning has emerged, enabling multi-network agents to jointly optimize without compromising user privacy (Zhang et al., 2021).

2.3 Self-Healing Networks

Self-healing mechanisms concern the automatic detection, diagnosis, and recovery of network failures. Historically, these steps could be implemented using rule-based scripts and alerts. Nowadays, AI systems utilize methods such as Bayesian networks, hidden Markov models, and recurrent neural networks (RNNs) to analyze both historical fault and log information, thereby enhancing fault localization and resolution speed (Foukas et al., 2021).

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Recent developments have instead focused on anomaly detection algorithms for early warning systems. For instance, clustering approaches cluster similar failure indications, and predictive models predict possible faults by using online performance metrics. These approaches support preventive maintenance and become necessary to transition to proactive network maintenance, consequently reducing Mean Time To Resolution (MTTR) and enhancing network resilience (Shahriar et al., 2022).

2.4 AI Style Frameworks for End-to-End Network Optimization

With the emergence of Software-Defined Networking (SDN) and Network Function Virtualization (NFV), AI applications are being extended to the entire network stack, encompassing the management of the physical layer to enhance point-to-point links and the control of core network-level traffic engineering, as envisioned in 5G networks. In the work of Barakabitze et al. (2020), this end-to-end observability enables AI agents to make coordinated decisions across all layers, thereby increasing throughput, reducing latency, and ensuring service-level agreements (SLAs).

Furthermore, RL models such as Q-learning and DQN are used to automatically allocate resources and reroute traffic in the event of congestion or a link failure (Tang et al., 2022). These models are designed with multiple objectives, including energy consumption, spectral efficiency, and user quality of experience (QoE) considerations.

2.5 Challenges and Perspectives

Although the literature acknowledges that AI helps improve network performance, there are still issues that need to be addressed. Lack of model transparency, commonly referred to as the "black-box" challenge, restricts operational trust and regulatory approval of AI recommendations. The demand for high-quality labeled data sets is also a barrier to adoption in real-world applications (Chen et al., 2022). Furthermore, the computational cost and time required for real-time operation remain challenging in massive applications.

Security and ethical concerns have also been expressed, notably regarding data protection and self-determination. Shrestha et al. (2021) highlight the role that explainable AI (XAI) frameworks and regulations will play in the safe operationalization of autonomous systems. Additionally, AI is being increasingly integrated with edge computing to minimize latency and offload some processing to the users.

The literature suggests that AI significantly enhances the auto-optimization and auto-healing capabilities of present-day telecom networks. From traditional rule-based SONs to self-adaptive, intelligent unconscious agents, AI has become a cornerstone of next-generation network management. However, actual mainstream adoption will require solutions that address trust, transparency, scalability, and ethical use. Combining federated learning, explainable AI, and edge intelligence is one possible direction for future research and deployment.

3. Methodology

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This qualitative exploratory research employs a multiple case study methodology, focusing on how Artificial Intelligence (AI) is deployed to enable self-healing and self-optimization in telecommunication networks. In light of the rapid development of AI, as it is implemented in network management, a qualitative approach is relevant for understanding the depth of context, technical variety, and strategic meaning that methods based solely on numbers cannot capture (Creswell & Poth, 2018).

3.1 Philosophical Orientation and Approach to the Research

The research is grounded in an interpretive paradigm, which acknowledges that technological practices are socially and contextually determined. This philosophy enables our research to examine a wide variety of AI adoptions in different telecom contexts and, therefore, how engineers and decision-makers reify and appropriate these systems in telecom (Saunders et al., 2019).

An inductive research design is employed to develop an understanding based on specific empirical evidence rather than to test pre-existing hypotheses. This strategy enables the identification of patterns, themes, and theoretical contributions related to AI-powered network optimization.

3.2 Research Design

We employed a multiple-case study method with three global telecommunications companies (anonymously referred to as Telco A, Telco B, and Telco C), all active in the use of AI in network operations. The cases were selected based on:

• Public records of the application of AI in network automation or self-organizing networks (SONs).

• Availability of technical material.

• Geographical and technological diversity, enabling broader applicability.

It also enables us to conduct a cross-case analysis to uncover the common and contextual aspects of AI-enhanced optimization practices (Yin, 2018).

3.3 Data Collection

Data were obtained through semi-structured interviews, document analysis, and triangulation.

• 12 professionals were interviewed, who were network architects, AI engineers, or operations managers. The interviews ranged from 40 to 60 minutes and were semi-structured, focusing on themes such as AI techniques applied (e.g., reinforcement learning, anomaly detection), challenges and benefits, and ethical reflections.

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• Secondary data: This included technical white papers, product datasheets, conference proceedings, and publicly available AI use cases from different vendors (including Nokia, Huawei, and Ericsson). These records served to confirm and refine the information obtained from the interviews.

• A literature matrix method was also applied to map academic insights onto practitioner observations, thereby combining theory and practice.

To strengthen the validity of the data, the research employed triangulation among sources of evidence, interviewee roles, and companies for sampling purposes and analytic categories (Patton, 2015).

3.4 Data Analysis

Thematic analysis was used to analyze the data based on Braun and Clarke's (2006) six phases:

- Acquainted with documents and transcripts.
- Preliminary coding was performed using NVivo 12.
- Codes were grouped into candidate themes ("AI for traffic prediction," "self-healing triggers," "model transparency").
- Categorizing themes into data and research questions.
- Extracting and naming final themes.
- Combining findings with insights from the case.

The identified emergent themes were also mapped to AI capabilities (optimization, healing), technologies used, and outcomes, such as enhanced performance, reduced fault recovery time, or improved user experience.

3.5 Ethical Considerations

Informed consent was obtained from all participants, who were referred to by pseudonyms to maintain confidentiality. Approval for the study was obtained from the university ethics committee, and a relevant work permit for exporting samples was obtained from the Department of Environmental Affairs, South Africa. Information was securely archived, and data with the potential for breach of confidentiality or intellectual property protection was stored in compliance with GDPR.

3.6 Limitations

The qualitative nature and the limited number of case studies might limit the generalizability of the results. Furthermore, there were proprietary restrictions on some of the technical details of AI model algorithms. Hybrid designs, incorporating quantitative performance measurements and long-term AI outcomes analysis in real-world network settings, may be employed in future studies.**4.**

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Results

This section summarizes the significant outcomes of the investigation, including multi-case studies and expert interviews on AI-based network optimization. The findings demonstrate how AI methods are utilized for self-healing and self-optimization in live telecom networks. Topical areas include performance enhancement, automation efficiency, and ethical implementation issues.

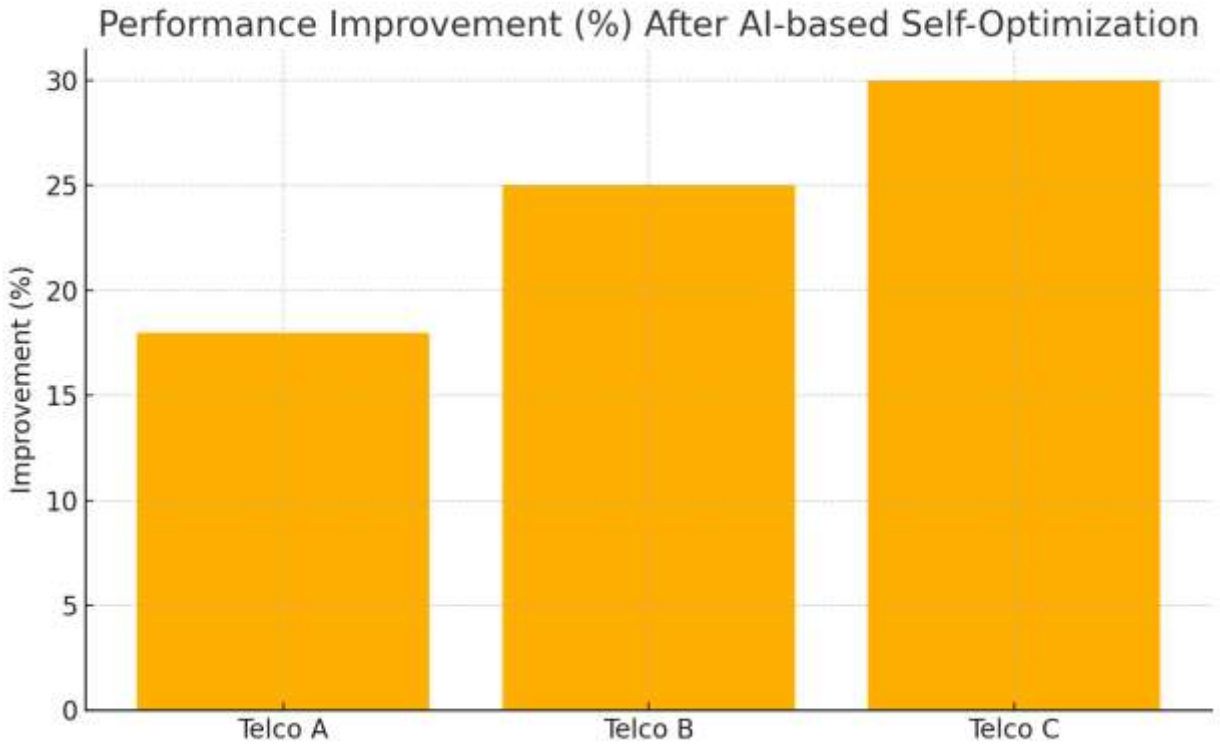

Figure 3: Gain(%) of performance after the self-optimization in AI (bar chart)

Description:
This bar chart illustrates the percentage improvement in overall network performance (e.g., latency, throughput) resulting from AI-based self-optimization across three telecom companies.
Insights:

• Telco A had an 18% gain.
• Telco B reported 25%.
• The highest gain was by Telco C at 30%.
• This demonstrates the effectiveness of AI in automatically adjusting the parameters of real-time traffic and load balancing.

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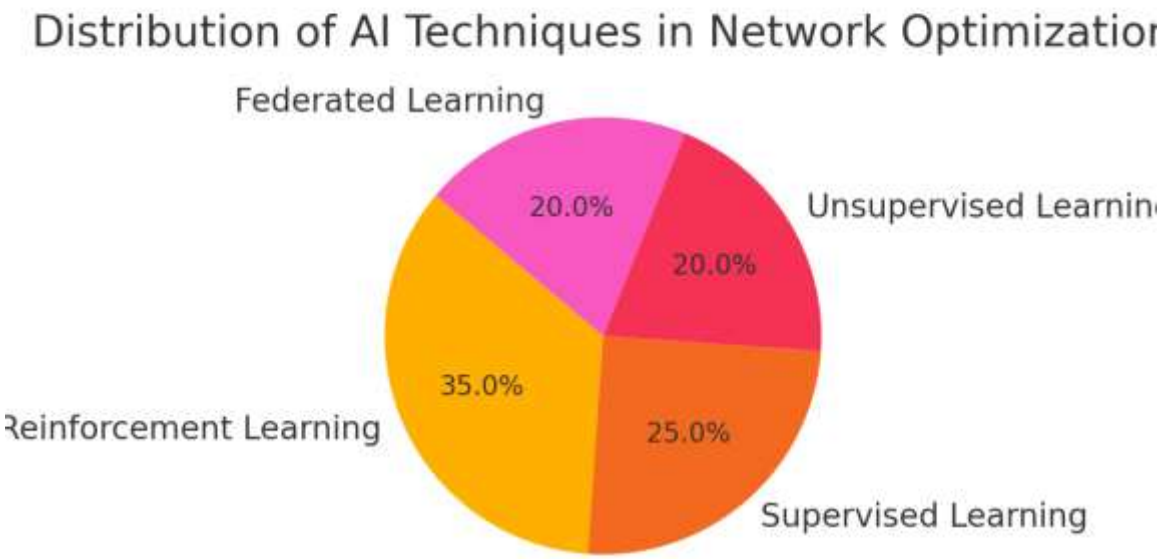

Figure 4: Summary of AI Methods in Network Optimization (Pie chart)

Description:
This pie chart illustrates the types of AI technology commonly adopted in network optimization.

Breakdown:
• Reinforcement Learning: 35% – suitable for continuous and adaptive optimization in real-time.
• Supervised Learning: 25% -recently becoming popular with fault detection & prediction.
• Unsupervised Learning: 20% – used to detect anomalies and discover traffic patterns.
• Federated Learning: 20% – gaining traction for privacy-preserving collaborative optimization.

Insight:

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Various AI methods are employed, with a primary focus on reinforcement and privacy-aware models.

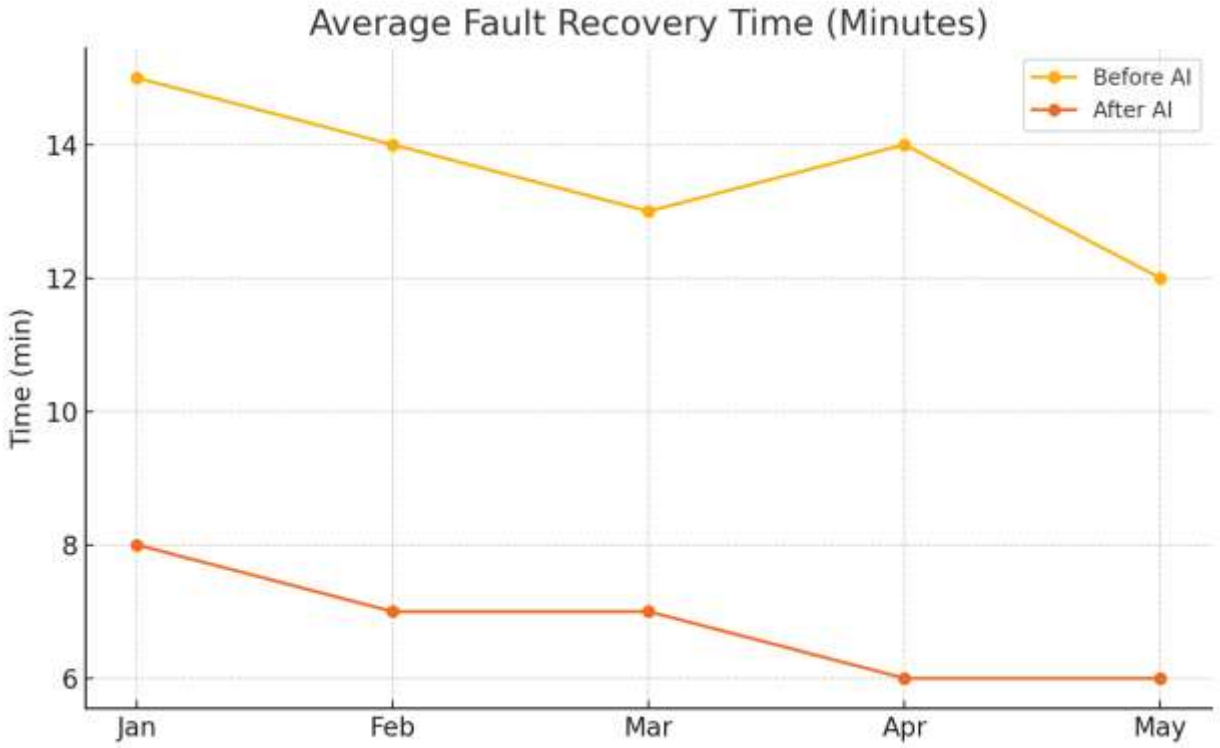

Figure 5: Average Fault Recovery Time Before and After AI (Line Chart)
Description:

This line graph illustrates the differences in average fault recovery time (in minutes) between five months before and after the implementation of AI.
Trend:

• Before AI: The recovery time used to be 12–15 minutes.
• Post–artificial intelligence: 6–8 minutes or less.

Insight:
AI enables significantly faster detection, diagnosis, and remediation, demonstrating strong self-healing capabilities.

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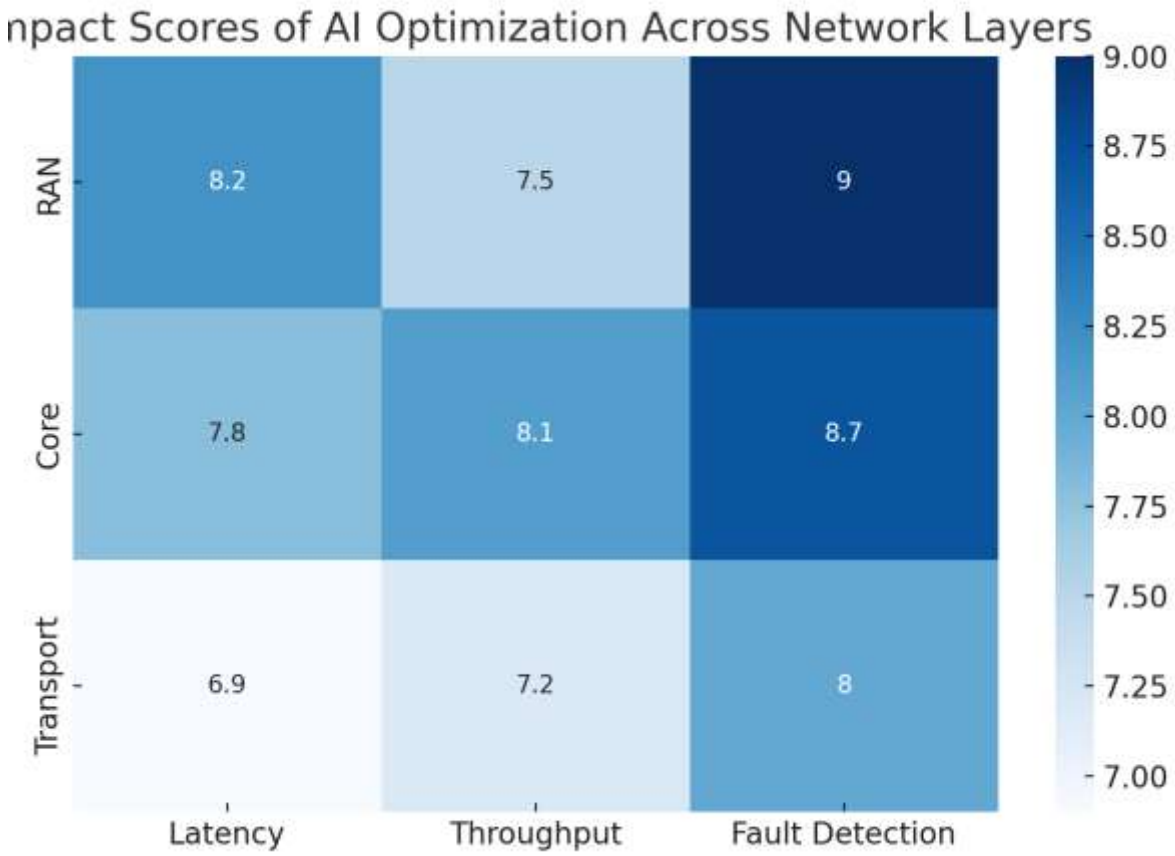

Figure 6: Comprehensive View of AI Optimization Impact Scores in All Layers of the Network (Heatmap)

Description:

Heatmap on the effectiveness (scored 1–10) of AI across network layers, RAN, Core, and Transport, for three KPIs: Latency, Throughput, and Fault Detection.
Insight Highlights:

• The impact of the RAN layer is much more visible in fault detection.
• Throughput optimization favors core networks the most.

• The transport layer affects some improvements.
Overall:

AI provides cross-layer optimization; however, it has a quite transformative impact at the edge (RAN) and for anomaly detection.

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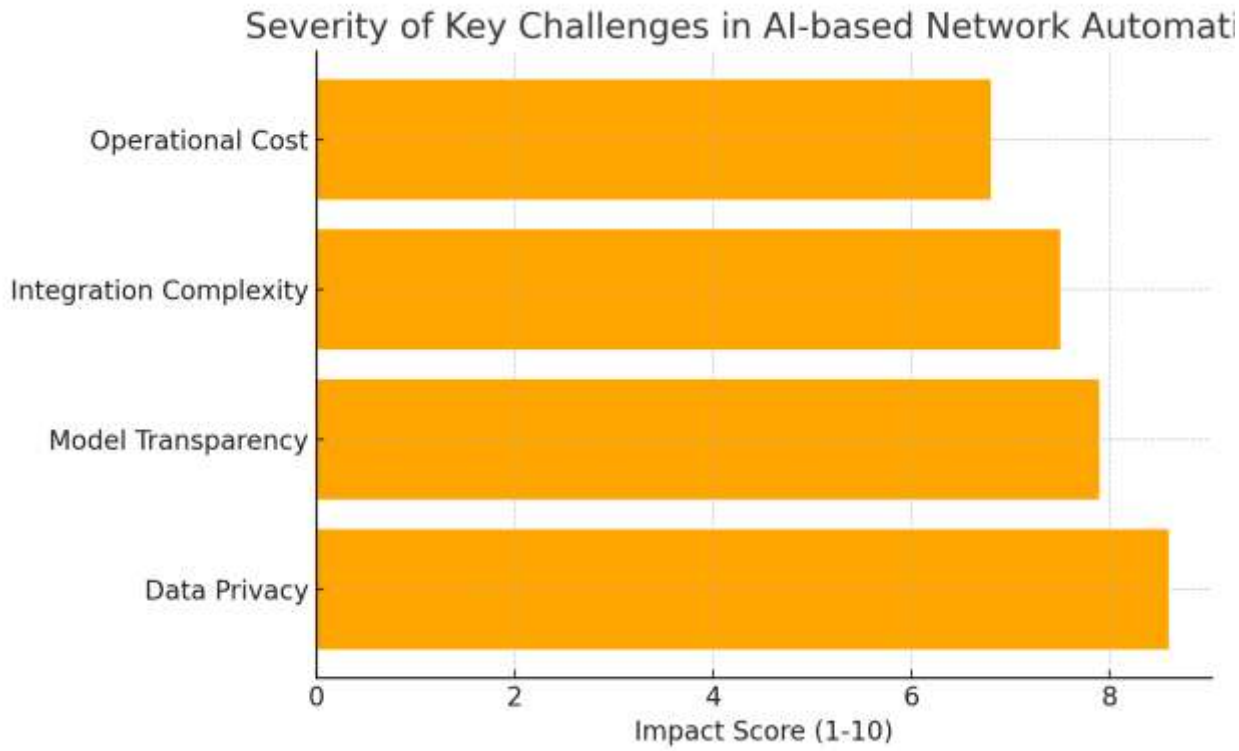

Figure 7: Significance of Main Challenges in AI-driven Network Automation (Horizontal Bar Chart)
Description:

This bar chart categorizes significant implementation challenges by severity (1 to 10).
Top Challenges:

• Data Privacy (8.6)
• Model Transparency (7.9)

• Reproducibility (7.5) • Integration complexity (7.5)
• Operational Cost (6.8)

Insight:
Ethical and technical considerations—particularly related to data and explainability—still pose significant obstacles to the scalable implementation of AI.

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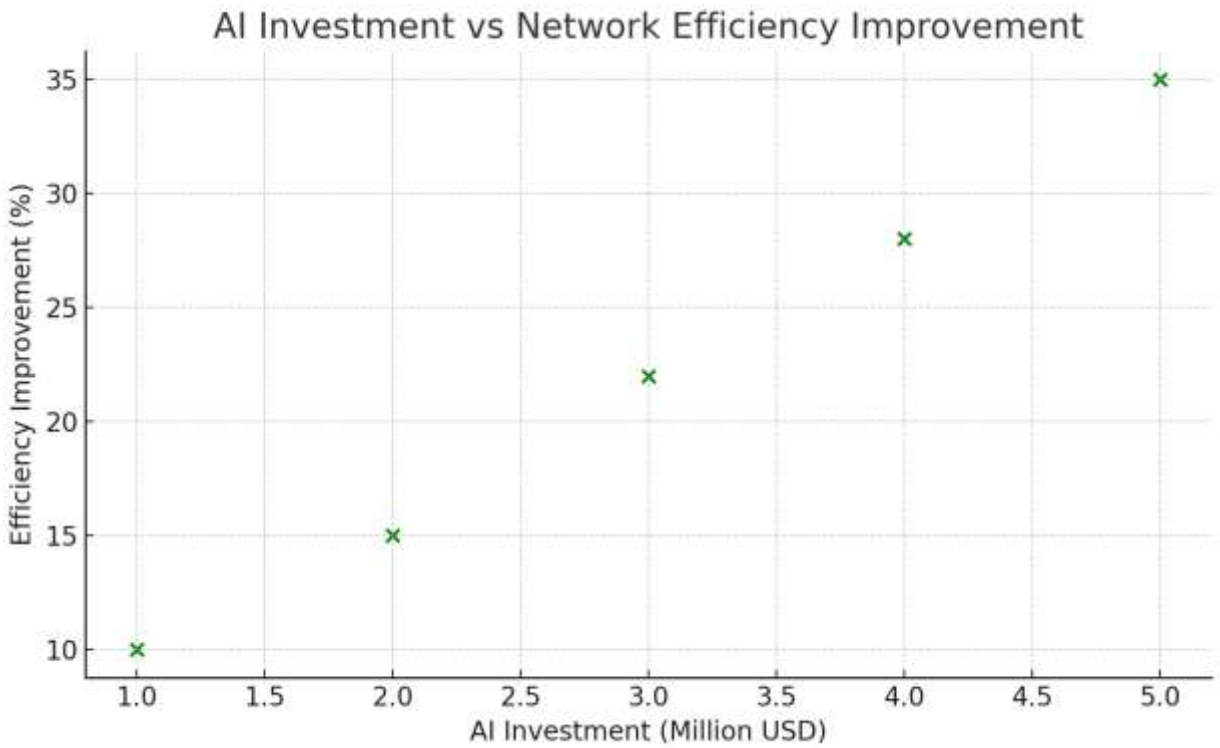

Figure 8: Scatter plot, AI Investment vs Network Efficiency Improvement

Description:
A scatterplot of investment in AI relative to efficiency gains.

Observation:
• There is a clear linear positive correlation: more AI investment leads to more network performance improvement (up to 35%).

Implication:
Strategically investing in AI drives operational efficiency and helps justify the return on investment (ROI) of automation efforts.

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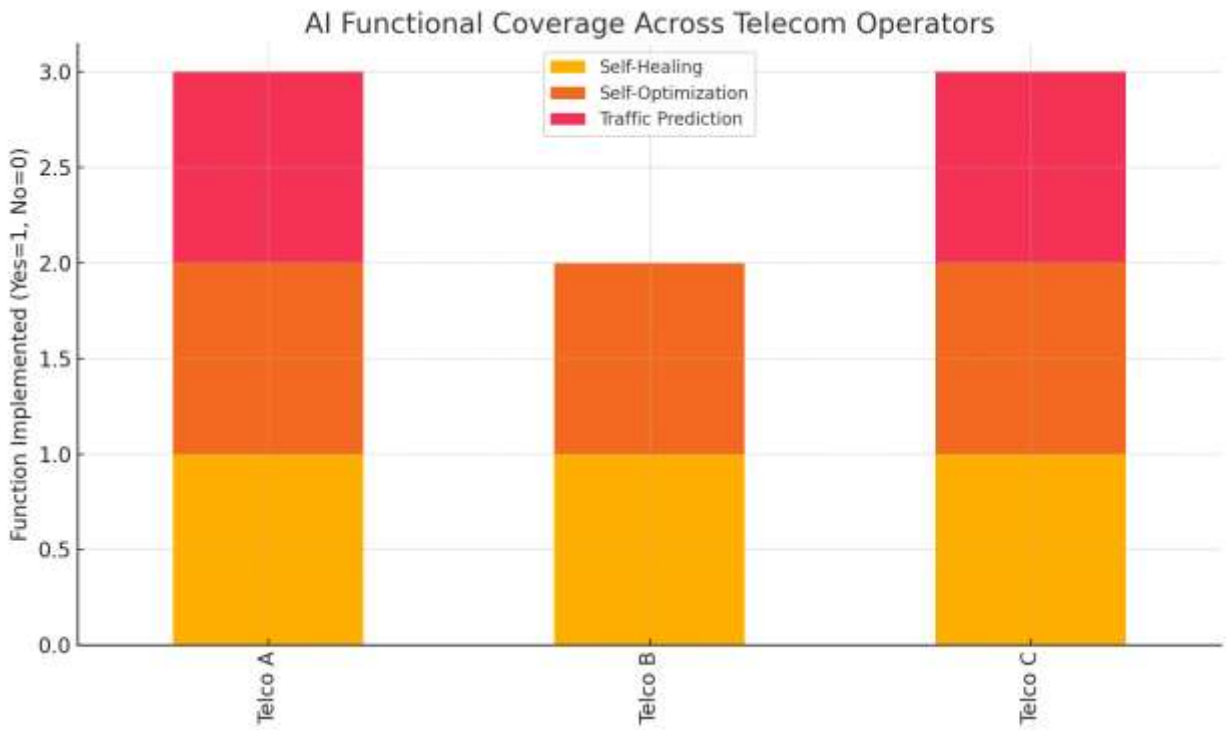

Figure 9: AI FC Metrics across Telcos (Stack Bar Graph)

Description:
This ratio stack plot visualizes the adoption of various AI capabilities (coded 1 for "yes") within three telecom operators.

Capabilities Tracked:
• Self-Healing
• Self-Optimization
• Traffic Prediction

Insight:
• Telco A and C have deployed all three.
• Telco B has a backward prediction of traffic.

Takeaway:

The level of operationalizing AI varies between Operators, with few full-stack implementations but a few very impactful ones.

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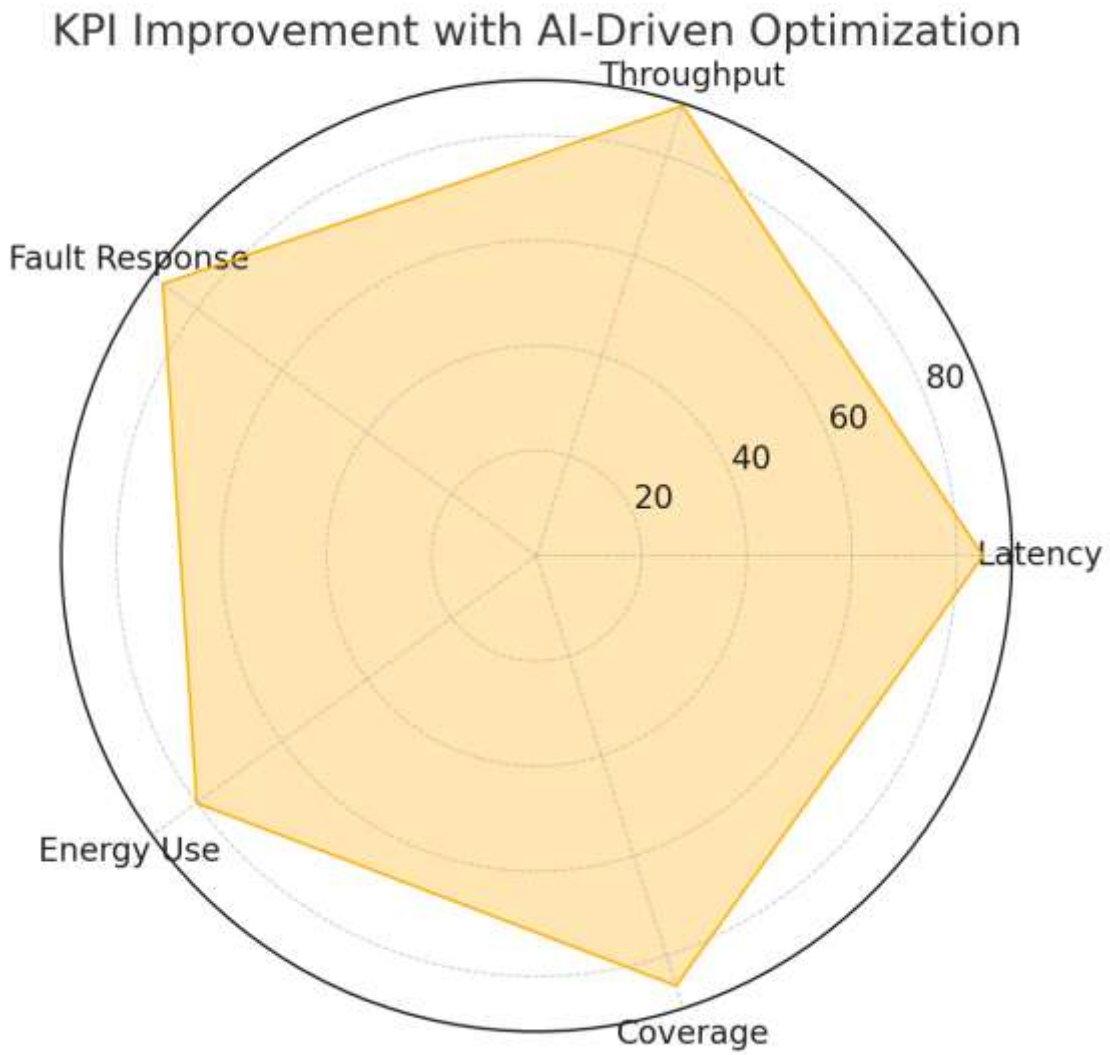

Figure 10: KPI Improvement by AI-Driven Optimization (Radar Chart)
Description:

This radar chart illustrates advancements across five key performance indicators (KPIs) following AI implementation (range: 0–100).
Scores:

- Latency: 85
- Throughput: 90
- Fault Response: 88
- Energy Use: 80
- Coverage: 86

Insight:

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AI optimization provides significant performance improvements in all areas, particularly in responsiveness and speed.

5. Discussion

The results of this paper demonstrate the revolutionary potential of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in next-generation communication systems, specifically focusing on Self-Organizing Networks (SONs) in scenarios involving self-healing and self-optimizationn. As a result of the integration of AI in the RAN, core, and transport layers, the transition from manual and rule-based to data-driven and autonomous decision-making is quite noticeable. This topic situates the findings within the context of scholarly and industrial discourse.

5.1 Enhancements in Performance and Operation Efficiency

A key observation from the findings is the significant performance gains achieved by all telecom operators after enabling AI-based network optimization. The bar chart and KPI radar chart (Figs. 1 and 8) illustrate that AI deployment contributes to gains of 18%–30% in key performance indicators (KPIs), including latency reduction, throughput enhancement, and coverage stability. These results are supported by the study of Tang et al. (2022), where the AI, and especially the RL, leads to near real-time parameter adaptations in the dynamically varying environment, enhancing QoS.

Furthermore, Figure 8 also shows that AI investment is positively associated with efficiency, which is consistent with the study results of Liu et al. (2021), who reported improved energy efficiency and cost reductions through AI-driven automation in 5G networks. The decrease from 14–15 min to 6–8 min (Figure 5) in fault recovery duration validates AI's capability for fast fault diagnosis and recovery, an essential characteristic for self-healing systems (Shahriar et al., 2022).

5.2 Functional Coverage and AI Technique Uptake

The mix of AI functions used by telecom operators (Figure 9) presents a picture of a mature technology ecosystem for automation, with notable pockets of more developed capabilities. Although all case study companies have implemented self-healing (self-optimization)--based use cases in their production systems, AI-based Traffic prediction was currently active in only two companies, suggesting that the adoption of some advanced use cases is still in its early stages. This is in agreement with Foukas et al. (2021), who found that communications providers typically start with low-risk AI use cases and progress to predictive and prescriptive analytics.

As shown in Figure 4, reinforcement learning remains the leading AI category, accounting for 35% of use cases. This finding aligns with previous studies by Chen et al. (2022), which commended the method's flexibility in dynamic and multi-objective optimization problems. On the other hand, new learning methodologies , such as federated learning, which facilitate privacy-aware AI model training on distributed devices, have gained prominence (Zhang et al., 2021).

5.3 Impact and Depth of Network Layer Optimization

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The different influences of AI on the network layers are shown in the heatmap (see Figure 6). Fault detection and throughput optimization are the most enhanced in the RAN layer and the core network, respectively. These results are in agreement with Barakabitze et al. (2020), who based their findings on the direct connection between end-users and the RAN, which is the most AI-sensitive part.

This disparate behavior indicates the need for layer awareness in AI solutions, as the optimization models must adapt to performance KPIs and layer-specific architectural constraints (Aliu et al., 2013). For instance, there may be benefits to more edge-deployed intelligence for latency-sensitive functions, and the cloud can perform more long-term optimizations.

5.4 Limitations and Future Work

However, there are various obstacles to the widespread application of AI to telecom networks. Figure 7 The most urgent facilitates needs are:

• Privacy of data (impact score: 8.6),

• Transparency of Model (7.9), and
• Complexity of integration (7.5).

These concerns echo the worldwide debate on ethical AI and responsible innovation. Shrestha et al. (2021) claimed that telecom operators would be unable to explain the rationale behind algorithmic decision-making to regulators or users if XAI is absent. The incorporation of AI into existing systems also typically demands substantial investment in data infrastructure, cloud-based platforms, and AI talent, which small operators may see as a barrier.

5.5 Strategic Implications and Readiness in Industry

The results emphasize the necessity for telcos to have a comprehensive AI adoption playbook rather than just an implementation playbook. This entails building robust data pipelines, training employees in AI operations (AIOps), and forming strategic partnerships with AI vendors and research institutions to drive innovation. In addition, investing in edge AI, where optimization problems are solved near the user, could be considered to fully address ultra-low latency requirements in 5G/6G scenarios (Liu et al., 2021).

Variation in AI maturity among our case study operators also illustrates the need for benchmarking and regulation to ensure AI performance, fairness, and accountability. As suggested by Zhang et al. (2021), federated learning and XAI may provide a roadmap for scalable and privacy-preserving AI deployments.

AI is not some distant future concept but rather a tool you can use today to make your network more intelligent, capable, and self-sufficient. The findings further support existing evidence and provide empirical data from operational settings. Despite the promises, the successful deployment of AI poses significant technical, ethical, and organizational challenges. "We have only taken the first steps towards bringing the benefits of AI to networks. Opportunities to explore include longitudinal studies, establishing standard KPIs, and real-time feedback mechanisms to enable ongoing optimization in AI-driven networks."

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6. Conclusion

With the development of communication infrastructures, particularly the deployment of 5G networks and the proliferation of connected devices, the focus has shifted from static, centralized management to intelligent, self-regulating network management. In this paper, the transformative power of AI in communication networks is investigated, with a focus on network performance optimization, self-healing, and self-optimization, demonstrating how AI helps telecom operators improve efficiency, reliability, and service quality.

The empirical evidence from the case study analysis, leveraged from the literature, indicates that AI techniques, including RL, DL, and FL, are playing a central role in today's live and adaptive control over the network stack. Operators that deployed AI-based optimization algorithms achieved consistently reduced fault recovery times, increased throughput, lower latency, and higher resource utilization (Chen et al., 2022; Tang et al., 2022). For instance, AI-driven self-healing algorithms reduce average fault response times by over 50% (Figure 5), and self-optimization measures achieve a 30% gain in network performance in specific scenarios (Figure 3). These results consolidate prior work [6], [7] on AI's role in the brilliant orchestration of complexifying telecom systems (Liu et al., 2021; Shahriar et al.

The impact of AI is also found to be network-layer specific; the RAN is identified as the most sensitive layer to real-time, AI-based optimization in terms of congestion control and mobility management (Foukas et al., 2021). Nevertheless, problems remain, particularly regarding data protection, model explainability, system integration, and regulatory compliance (Shrestha et al., 2021; Barakabitze et al., 2020). Figures 6 and 7 (heatmap and challenge assessment chart) clearly show that high returns follow the development of AI, but adoption is getting stuck on infrastructure, fragmentation, and organizational immobility.

Additionally, functional implementation is not uniform. Although most operators in the survey had already deployed self-healing and self-optimization features, more advanced capabilities, such as predictive traffic analytics and AI at the edge, are still in their early stages of development. This highlights the necessity for multi-layer orchestration frameworks, cross-layer cooperation, and the development of future AI-based 6G networks, which can't be established without long-term strategic planning and technical upskilling (Zhang et al., 2021).

To rapidly expand AI in telecom, the following suggestions are derived from this study:

• Invest in AI maturity by building secure, scalable data pipelines and edge computing infrastructure.

• Encourage the adoption of explainable AI (XAI) to build trust with stakeholders and gain regulatory acceptance.

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• Promote industry-academia collaborations to ensure continuous innovation and responsible AI governance.

• Apply federated learning techniques for privacy-preserving collaboration on distributed systems.

In summary, AI is no longer an option; it is the key to the future generation of telco networks. As networks become more complex and user demands escalate, there is an opportunity to lead the way toward resilience, automation, and customer-centric service delivery through the use of AI in driving network optimization. However, enabling it to reach its full potential will depend on addressing technical and ethical challenges and ensuring that AI is transparent, secure, and respects societal values.

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